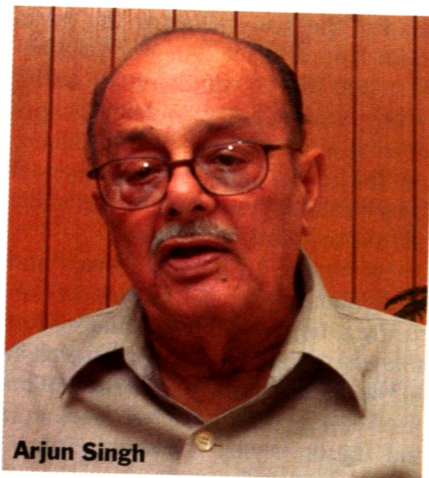




Arjun Singh

BATTLE AT HOME

Arjun Singh finds himself in a spot as his family is charged with harassing the granddaughter-in-law for dowry



Madhvendra Singh

It's the kind of scandalous domestic dispute that finds itself splashed over a tabloid's inside pages but what makes it front page news is that the accused is the Union minister for Human Resource Development. When Moradabad landlord Madhvendra Singh lodged an FIR against Arjun Singh and his family under the Indian Penal Code and the Anti-Dowry Act on July 29 alleging that they were harassing his daughter Priyanka Singh, the district police dragged its feet, initially even refusing to register a case until an order from the court of the additional chief judicial magistrate, Chandausi.

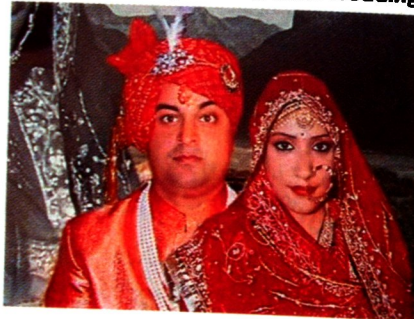
The charges are serious. According to the FIR, Arjun's son Abhimanyu, grandson Abhijit, daughter-in-law Beena, Abhimanyu's father-in-law Dileep Singh and sister-in-law Mandakini Singh reached Madhvendra's house in Moradabad's Narauli village and assaulted his daughter Priyanka (who is married to Abhijit). The police, says Madhvendra, did not take him seriously. But the senior superintendent of police Prem Prakash insists the delay was entirely their fault. "It was necessary for us to meet some prior investigations before registering an FIR," he says.

The FIR says Madhvendra's family gave Abhimanyu's family dowry worth Rs 60 lakh. But after a few months of the marriage, Priyanka's in-laws demanded a Mercedes. Her parents succumbed to the demand with Madhvendra and his wife Gayatri travelling to Abhimanyu's house in Bangalore to hand over Rs 2 lakh. However, the demand for dowry went up and the next thing sought was a

flat in south Delhi.

Though Arjun has distanced himself from the case, saying he "did not even attend the marriage ceremony", Madhvendra says they had agreed to the wedding only because of the minister's stature. The relationship between Arjun and his son Abhimanyu has always been fraught with complications. A poignant moment in the ongoing family drama came last year when the minister was chief guest at the golden jubilee function of St Joseph's

HAPPIER TIMES: A file picture of Abhijit and Priyanka at their wedding



SHAME OR SHAM?

■ **Priyanka's father Madhvendra lodged an FIR against Arjun and six others including his son Abhimanyu and grandson Abhijit under the Anti-Dowry Act.**

■ **Madhvendra alleged that his daughter was assaulted and harassed by her in-laws.**

■ **He also alleged that her in-laws demanded a flat in south Delhi before which they had also asked for a Mercedes.**

■ **Arjun says he has nothing to do with the case or the marriage.**

School in Bhopal. As a former head boy, Abhimanyu was to be felicitated on the occasion but gave the function a go-by when he heard who the chief guest was. The minister, on his part, refused to go to his Bhopal home when he heard Abhimanyu was in town.

Abhimanyu left the Singh household in the early 1980s as his father—then the all powerful Madhya Pradesh chief minister—didn't approve of him. Since then the son has established himself as an industrialist in Bangalore and is running a unit that manufactures poly-packs for industrial lubricants. His visits to Bhopal are rare and the last time he spent a reasonable amount of time with the family was during the 1996 Lok Sabha elections which Arjun fought as the working president of Congress (T) from Satna and lost.

Even as Arjun's political legacy has been bequeathed to the younger son Ajeya who was a minister in the Digvijay Singh cabinet between 1998 and 2003, the siblings hardly ever meet or talk to each other. His daughter, Beena—who shares her name with Abhimanyu's wife—is a powerful force in the family and has not spoken to Abhimanyu in years. While it might hurt an ageing Arjun to see his family at odds with each other, the humiliation of a dowry harassment case from a granddaughter-in-law whose family he hardly ever meets must be particularly potent. And while the CBI, to whom the case is now referred, is yet to register the case, controversy, it seems, has made it a habit of dogging Arjun Singh.

*by Shyam Lal Yadav in Narauli with
Ambresh Mishra in Bhopal*